On September 14, a terrorist's bomb destroyed a building in Beirut where the president-elect of Lebanon, Bashir Gemayel, was giving a speech. It threw a nation where chaos had been a matter of day-to-day routine for more than a decade into even greater confusion. Israeli forces immediately responded to Gemayel's assassination by moving into West Beirut and, in fierce fighting, engaged members of the Lebanese army and leftist Muslims, including those believed responsible for the bombing.

I'd expected Saturday, September 18, to be a quiet day: Nancy had left on a brief trip on behalf of her war against drugs, and the only event of the day should have been my noon radio broadcast. But, as my diary reminds me, "Unfortunately things changed. In Beirut, Haddad's Christian Phalanges militia entered a Palestine refugee camp and massacred men, women and children. The Israelis did nothing to prevent or halt it. George Shultz and I met and agreed upon a blunt statement which he delivered to the Israeli ambassador. It was a sad day and one which may very well set our peace efforts back."

The incident touched off a new storm of anti-Israeli sentiment, much of it directed at us. Brezhnev sent me a message accusing Israel of perpetrating a "bloody orgy" and implied we were a party to it. In my response, I said, "I share the revulsion of the entire American people for the deplorable events which have recently occurred in Beirut," and added that the Soviet Union shared a responsibility to end the deadly chaos in Lebanon.

The assassination of Bashir Gemayel, just as Philip Habib seemed to be making great progress in bringing the various sides together, changed everything. After that, Israel and Syria both refused to live up to their agreement to leave Lebanon. The hostilities continued and, more than a year later, Beirut became the focal point of the saddest day of my presidency, perhaps the saddest day of my life.